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GLOBAL VILLAGE WEARS A FESTIVE LOOK

■ Visitors throng Global Village during the Eid Al Adha holidays. Global Village is running extended opening days for the season until May 31, making it a strong pick for a full evening out. Residents also filled malls, parks and corniches across the UAE as they enjoyed the extended weekend.

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BUSINESS

Laptop prices are exploding in 2026 — and AI is the biggest reason why | P9

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Siddaramaiah steps down, ending era in Karnataka politics | P13



SPORT

Fashion-first Osaka irks opponent at French Open in Paris | P14

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UAE, GULF STATES SLAM IRAN ATTACK ON KUWAIT AS BLATANT VIOLATION

Reports say 60-day US-Iran deal awaits Trump approval

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

Gulf nations strongly condemned an Iranian missile and drone attack targeting Kuwait, calling it a dangerous escalation and a blatant violation of the country's sovereignty amid growing tensions between the United States and Iran despite a fragile ceasefire.

The UAE, Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Bahrain issued statements expressing solidarity with Kuwait after warning sirens sounded across the country and air defence systems intercepted incoming missiles and drones late Wednesday.

In a statement, the UAE Ministry of Foreign Affairs described the attacks as "a flagrant violation" of Kuwait's sovereignty and a threat to its security and stability, reaffirming the UAE's full support for measures aimed at protecting the country.

Gulf Cooperation Council Secretary-General Jassem Mohamed Al Budaiwi said the attacks violated international law, the UN Charter and principles of good neighbourliness.

'Malicious attacks'

Egypt also condemned what it described as "malicious attacks" against Kuwait, stressing that the security of Gulf states formed an integral part of Egyptian and Arab national security.

Kuwait's Foreign Ministry called the attacks a "dangerous

US THREATENS TO SANCTION OMAN

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent threatened yesterday to target ally Oman if it helped impose a tolling system in the key Strait of Hormuz, warning of sanctions against all parties involved in such actions.

"Oman, in particular, should know that the US Treasury will aggressively target any actors involved — directly or indirectly — in facilitating tolls for the Strait and any willing partners will be penalised," Bessent warned in a post on X.

He said the United States would "not tolerate any effort to impose a tolling system in the Strait of Hormuz."

On Wednesday, US President Donald Trump appeared to threaten Oman when asked about a possible short-term arrangement allowing it and Iran to control the Hormuz, saying he would "blow them up" if Muscat did so. Yesterday's threat by Bessent followed hours after the US Treasury sanctioned Iran's Strait Authority, Tehran's new agency that collects fees for transiting the strait.

Washington extended the threat of sanctions to anyone paying the fees, because they "may be providing support to and receiving services from" Iran's Revolutionary Guards, and therefore may "be exposed to sanctions risk."

—AFP



AFP

■ Vessels anchored in the Strait of Hormuz, off Khasab on Oman's northern Musandam Peninsula.

escalation" and "blatant aggression", warning that they undermined diplomatic efforts aimed at reducing tensions in the region.

The latest flare-up marked another test for the fragile seven-week ceasefire between Washington and Tehran, which has repeatedly come under strain from military exchanges, maritime tensions and disputes over negotiations to end the war.

US Central Command ac-

cused Iran of carrying out an "egregious ceasefire violation", saying missiles launched from Iran were intercepted over Kuwait late Wednesday, hours after American forces carried out fresh strikes in southern Iran.

US officials said American forces earlier struck missile launch sites and a ground-control station in Bandar Abbas while intercepting drones near the Strait of Hormuz that were deemed a threat to maritime

traffic and regional security. Iran said it had retaliated against a US military base in a Gulf state after earlier American strikes, though it did not publicly identify the country.

Despite the escalation, diplomatic efforts appeared to continue behind the scenes.

Truce extension talks

Axios reported that US and Iranian negotiators had reached a 60-day memorandum of understanding aimed at extending the ceasefire and launching negotiations over Iran's nuclear programme, though President Donald Trump had not yet given final approval, citing US officials and a regional source involved in mediation efforts.

Washington and Tehran have repeatedly accused each other of violating the ceasefire while continuing indirect negotiations through mediators including Oman and Pakistan. Pakistani Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar is expected to meet US Secretary of State Marco Rubio in Washington today to push forward Iran-US peace efforts.

Trump has continued expressing confidence that talks are progressing, even as tensions around the Strait of Hormuz persist. The latest incidents have renewed concerns across the Gulf that any collapse of the ceasefire could rapidly destabilise the wider region, threaten shipping routes and draw neighbouring states deeper into the confrontation.

— with WAM and AFP inputs
SEE ALSO P5-8, 12

UAE among world's top 10 FDI destinations

It also ranked 2nd globally among emerging markets for third year in a row

The US topped the global rankings, followed by Canada, Japan, China and Germany.

Strong performance

Kearney attributed the UAE's strong performance to economic growth of 5.5 per cent in 2025, continued efforts to reduce regulatory barriers for investors, and the launch of a \$10 billion national investment fund supporting the country's Investment Strategy 2031.

The report also cited ongoing infrastructure and technology development, along with a stable and flexible legislative environment, as key factors supporting investor confidence.

The survey was conducted in January 2026 and included 507 senior executives from global companies with annual revenues exceeding \$500 million.

Kearney said rising geopolitical tensions were viewed by investors as the biggest risk facing the global economy over the next year, ahead of commodity price increases and political instability in developed economies.

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

The UAE retained its position as the world's ninth most attractive destination for foreign direct investment in 2026, remaining among the top 10 global economies for attracting overseas capital, according to Kearney's 2026 Foreign Direct Investment Confidence Index.

The report showed the UAE recorded the highest level of economic optimism among all global markets, with a net optimism score of 42 per cent, ahead of Japan at 41 per cent and Canada, Germany and Thailand at 39 per cent.

The UAE also ranked second globally among emerging markets for the third consecutive year, behind China and ahead of Saudi Arabia, while Brazil and Mexico placed fourth and fifth, respectively.

MODEST GAINS

Oil turns volatile again on fresh US-Iran strikes

DUBAI

BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

Oil prices rebounded yesterday after the United States and Iran exchanged fresh strikes, disrupting hopes that the Middle East conflict could ease soon.

Crude prices rose as much as 3 per cent during trading, partly reversing sharp declines from the previous session before settling into modest gains.

The gains come a day after both Brent and US crude fell more than 5 per cent after markets priced in the possibility that Iran could accept an agreement to reopen the Strait of Hormuz within about a month.

"A fresh exchange of strikes between the two countries is testing the fragile ceasefire and forcing a reassessment of the chances of a near-term agreement which can reopen the Strait of Hormuz and dial down the pressure the crisis is putting on the global economy," AJ Bell investment director Russ Mould said.

Market watchers deemed yesterday's escalation as the most serious clash between Washington and Tehran since an April ceasefire began. Kuwait also reported responding to incoming fire, while fighting intensified in southern Lebanon after Israel declared large areas combat zones.